Pulicat subsequently became the headquarters of the VOC for its trading operations up and down the Coromandel coast, with slaving as a sideline. Between 1621 and 1665, VOC ships transported 38,441 slaves from the Coromandel coast, chiefly through Pulicat, for sale to Dutch plantations in Batavia, an activity done with the connivance of local rulers and helped along by several local famines.[3] By such means the VOC became the wealthiest private company the world had ever seen, paying 40 per cent dividends to its shareholders in Amsterdam – which may help to explain why the Dutch named their fort at Pulicat Guelderland.

In 1690 the VOC shifted its Coromandel headquarters from Pulicat to Nagapattinam, which remained under the control of the VOC until 1781, when it fell to the East India Company (EICo) following two sea-battles fought directly offshore between two evenly matched fleets, the British and the French.

When Ludovico di Varthema stepped ashore at Nagapattinam in 1505 he had unknowingly arrived in what had been the Chola heartland for fifteen hundred years and more. Nagapattinam stands at the mouth of the Kollidam, the southern channel of the Cauvery River, and it was here within this fecund triangle of silt threaded with waterways that the Chola kings established their temple capitals: initially, inland at Uraiyur; then on the coast at Kaveripattinam (today Poompuhar); later still in Thanjavur; and then, as their territories continued to expand, at a new site further north which the ruler of the day named Gangaikondacholapuram – ‘the city of the Chola who took the Ganges’ – which became their fourth and last capital.

No new visitor to these parts should even think of travelling between Thanjavur and Gangaikondacholapuram without stopping halfway to admire the Nageshwaram temple, one of six major Shiva temples in the town of Kumbakonam. For the first-time visitor it is all too easy to